fMRIght Hook Test

Shooting guide for Team 2

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The whole guide in one paragraph. We are filming **18 product videos** (called **bases**). Each base exists in **4 versions** that are identical except for the **first 3 seconds**. We run all 72 as Instagram Reels ads with equal budgets and measure how many people watch past 3 seconds. Then we check whether the brain model predicted which opening would win. The videos must look like real creator ads that brands pay to run, because the people we want to sell to judge exactly those videos every week.

What each person does

1. **Everyone:** build a swipe file (section 5), list products you own, fill in **3 Base Cards**.
2. **Lucas:** approves every Base Card and picks the best hook for each opening *before* anyone films.
3. **Each shooter:** films and edits their first base. Lucas checks it. Then the other two.
4. **Ben:** runs the checker on every base. Anything that fails gets fixed and re-dropped.
5. **Everyone:** the guess round, ranking the openings of bases you did *not* shoot.
6. **Ben:** scores all 72 clips with the model, freezes the study, launches the ads.

The five rules that break the study if ignored

1. Inside a base, the **body is identical** in all four versions. Same footage, audio, cut, length, to the frame.
2. Every opening is **exactly 3.00 seconds (90 frames)**. Every version is **exactly 20.00 seconds**.
3. Film at **30 fps**. Not 24, 29.97 or 60.
4. **No visible brands** unless Ben already has the brand's written OK. No copyrighted music.
5. Nothing that fails ad review: no health claims, before/after shots, supplements, weight loss, alcohol, cannabis.

1. What we are testing, and who it is for

We can run a model that predicts how a human brain responds to a video, from the video file alone. Nobody has shown whether that prediction says anything useful about short-form video. This study settles it. If the model adds nothing, we publish that: a clean “no” is a real result.

The videos have to look like the work our future customers actually judge. If we film generic clips, any result only speaks for generic clips. If we film what they review every week, a result becomes something we can put in front of them.

Who buys	Who they are	What they judge	Bases
Hook-Rate Hunter (Persona C, primary)	Creative strategists and performance marketers at direct-to-consumer (DTC) brands or their agencies. They launch 10+ creator-style ads a month on Instagram and TikTok.	Paid creator ads. **Hook rate is already their main number**, the exact thing we measure.	12
Draft Gatekeeper (Persona B, secondary)	Influencer-agency campaign managers and brand creator-program leads. They approve 20+ creator drafts a month before posting.	Sponsored creator posts, before they go live.	6
Working Creator	UGC creators and micro-influencers paid to make brand content.	They make what B and C judge, so both sets of bases cover them.	—

Why this design matches real practice. Creative strategists already do “hook stacking”: one body, 3–5 different openings, launched to see which stops the scroll. Their documented pain is “a batch of 8–15 videos arrives and nobody knows which will survive past day 3.” Our four openings on one body are that exact decision. Only about 5% of their ads end up as winners, so a tool that picks better openings before spending money is worth real dollars to them.

2. Words we use (and the ones we avoid)

Use these words exactly. Most mix-ups on a team come from two people meaning different things by “the video” or “the hook.”

Word	Meaning	Don't say
Base	One product video, filmed by one shooter, that exists in four variants. 18 in the study.	video, concept, ad
Variant	One of the four finished files of a base. Identical to the other three except the opening.	version, cut
Opening	The first 3 seconds (90 frames) of a variant. One of: **spoken, visual, text, cold**.	intro
Hook	What fills an opening to stop the scroll: a spoken line, an on-screen line, or a motion moment. The cold opening has *no* hook.	(don't use it to mean “opening”)
Body	Everything after 3 seconds. Frame-for-frame identical in all four variants.	main video, content
Plate	A plain 3-second shot of the product, nothing happening. Used for the cold opening and under the text opening.	B-roll, filler

Word	Meaning	Don't say
Proof moment	The roughly 2-second shot in the body where you can *see* the product work.	money shot
Base Card	The one-page plan for a base, filled in before filming (section 6).	brief, script
Body format	The beat structure the body follows, picked from a fixed menu (section 7).	template, style
Swipe file	Your saved collection of real ads whose structure you can borrow (section 5).	inspo
Hook rate	People who watched 3+ seconds ÷ people the ad was shown to. Our main result.	thumb-stop rate, views
Hold rate	Share of viewers who reach 15 seconds. A secondary result.	retention
Frame	One still image. At 30 frames per second, 3 seconds = 90 frames.	—

3. What the videos should feel like: “native UGC”

UGC means user-generated content. The target: **a real person filming on their phone at home, a clip a brand would pay to run as an ad.** Not a commercial. Polished ads are a different product that performs differently, and they are not what our buyers review.

Do	Don't
Phone camera, window light, real rooms: kitchen counter, bathroom sink, desk, car	Studio lights, gimbal glide shots, perfect staging
One person talking like they're telling a friend	Reading a script word-for-word
Hands in frame, the product actually being used	The product sitting on a pedestal
Plain words: “this thing is so good”	Brand-speak: “revolutionary formula”
One honest downside in a review body	Pure hype (reads fake, and can fail ad review)
Captions on everything spoken (section 4)	Background music by default

> **The one-question test:** would you believe a friend posted this? If yes, the feel is right.

4. How a base is built

OPENING 0:00–0:03 frames 1–90	**BODY · 0:03–0:20 · frames 91–600 · identical in all four variants**			
spoken / visual text / cold	beat 1 0:03–0:06	beat 2 (proof moment) 0:06–0:12	beat 3 0:12–0:17	beat 4 0:17–0:20

Every variant is exactly 20.00 seconds = 600 frames at 30 frames per second. Drawn to scale.

The four openings

Opening	What's on screen (0:00–0:03)	Sound	Captions / text
cold	The **plate**: steady close-up of the product, nothing happening.	Room sound only	None
text	**The same plate clip as cold**, reused, not reshot.	Same room sound	The hook line on screen, frame 1 to 90
spoken	The shooter on camera, saying the hook line to the lens.	The voice. **Finished by about 2.8 s** so it doesn't spill into the body.	Burned-in captions of the line
visual	A motion moment: a fast push-in, the product dropped into frame, or the proof moment shown first.	Natural sound of the action	None

Why cold and text share one clip: the only difference between them is then the words on screen, which makes that comparison clean.

Captions (decided)

Over 70% of Reels are watched with the sound off. A spoken opening without captions would lose for that reason alone, which tells us nothing about the brain model, and almost no real UGC ad ships without captions. So:

- **Every spoken word gets burned-in captions**, in the spoken opening and in the body.
- Lucas makes **two saved style presets** and everyone uses them: **Caption** (for speech) and **Hook text** (for the text opening). Same font, size, color and position in every base.
- Body captions are created **once, on the body**, so they are identical in all four variants.
- The visual and cold openings have no speech, so no captions.

Where text may go on screen

Instagram covers the top and bottom of a Reel with its own buttons and captions. Keep all text and the product **out of the top 14% and the bottom 35%** of the frame (Meta's Reels safe zone). The middle of the frame is always safe.

5. Where the ideas come from

Skilled UGC creators don't invent from scratch. They copy **structures** that are already working and fill them with their own product and words. Creative strategists, our main buyer, do this every week. Most of us haven't made content to grow an audience, so this process does that job for us.

1. **Build a swipe file (about 30 minutes).** Search your product's category in the **Meta Ad Library** (facebook.com/ads/library, free, shows every ad running right now) and in **TikTok Creative Center → Top Ads**. Save 5 ads whose first 3 seconds made you stop. For each, write one line: what happened in the first 3 seconds, and which body format it used.
2. **Copy the structure, never the words or the footage.** “Opens on the result, then shows how” is a structure. Their exact line or clip is not ours to use.
3. **List 6 products you own and actually use.** Keep the 3 with the clearest proof moment that also pass the rules in section 12.
4. **Fill in one Base Card per product** (section 6). Write **5 hook lines for each opening type**. Volume is how you find a good one; the first idea is rarely the best.

5. **Send your 3 cards to Lucas.** He approves them and picks the best hook per opening. Paper is free; reshoots are not.

6. The Base Card: six blanks per base

#	Blank	What goes in it
1	**Product**	Something you own and use. Must pass section 12.
2	**Persona**	C (paid ad) or B (sponsored post). Each shooter does 2 C and 1 B.
3	**Problem**	The problem it solves, in one sentence a friend would say. (B bases: the routine it lives in instead.)
4	**Proof moment**	The 2-second shot where you can see it work. **No visible proof moment, no base.** This is the most important filter.
5	**Body format**	One from the menu in section 7.
6	**Hook lines**	5 per opening type from the menu in section 8. Lucas picks one of each.

A blank, printable Base Card is the last page of this guide.

7. Body formats (the 17 seconds after the opening)

Times are in the finished 20-second video. The body always runs 0:03 to 0:20.

Format	For	Beats
Problem → solution	C	0:03–0:07 already *in* the problem (don't announce it) · 0:07–0:13 product fixes it (proof moment) · 0:13–0:17 the result · 0:17–0:20 one-line verdict
Demo	C	0:03–0:06 setup · 0:06–0:12 proof moment · 0:12–0:17 result · 0:17–0:20 verdict
Honest review	C	0:03–0:07 "I've used this for a month" · 0:07–0:13 what's good (proof moment) · 0:13–0:17 one real downside · 0:17–0:20 verdict
Unboxing	C	0:03–0:07 box open · 0:07–0:10 first look · 0:10–0:16 first use (proof moment) · 0:16–0:20 first reaction
3 reasons	C	Three ~4-second reasons, each with its own shot · last 3 seconds: verdict
Routine integration	B	A morning, desk, gym, travel or study routine. The product shows up naturally as one step in the middle (proof moment), then the routine continues.

> **Two rules for every body.** (1) **Start mid-action.** If the body opens with its own attention-grabbing line, every variant gets a second hook and the openings stop mattering. (2) **Never refer back to the opening.** No "like I said." The body has to make sense after any of the four openings, including the silent one.

8. Hook menu, by opening

Each opening type has its own proven hook styles. Pick the strongest one for each type. The four openings do **not** have to say the same thing; each should be the best real-world version of its type. If all four are weak copies of one idea, they all perform the same and there is nothing for the model to predict.

Opening	Hook styles that work	Example (milk frother)
spoken on camera, captioned	**Callout**: name who it's for · **Question** · **Confession**: "I was today years old…"	"If you drink coffee every morning, you need this."
text over the plate, no voice	**POV** · **"Stop doing X"** · **Curiosity**: "I didn't expect this to work"	"POV: you stopped paying $6 for lattes"
visual motion, no voice, no text	**Result-first**: show the proof moment out of order · **Pattern interrupt**: the product dropped into frame, a fast push-in	Foam spilling over the rim of the mug
cold	None. The plate, nothing happening.	The frother next to a mug, still

9. What we film: the 18-base plan

12 Persona C bases: 6 high-volume DTC categories that pass ad review, 2 bases each, each with a different body format, the way real ad accounts test them.

Category	Base A body format	Base B body format
Home & kitchen	Demo	Problem → solution
Beauty / personal care (no skin claims, no before/after)	Routine demo	Honest review
Apparel & accessories	Try-on (demo)	3 reasons
Pet	Demo with pet	Unboxing
Food & drink (non-alcoholic)	Taste test (honest review)	Recipe in 15 seconds (demo)
Tech accessories	Unboxing	Problem → solution

6 Persona B bases, all routine integration, the kind of sponsored draft agencies approve: morning routine · work-from-home desk day · gym bag · travel packing · study session · get-ready-with-me.

Who films what

- Each shooter films **2 Persona C bases and 1 Persona B base**, so Lucas's UGC experience raises quality across the whole set, not in one corner.
- **No two bases share a product or category slot.** Claim yours in the group chat; first claim wins.
- Base numbers stay as assigned: Lucas 01–03, Ryan 04–06, Audrey 07–09, Ben 10–12, Cole 13–15, Julie 16–18.

10. Worked example: one base, start to finish

Base 07: a rechargeable milk frother, Persona C, demo format. Use it as the model for your own.

Step 1 · Plan on paper (15 min)

Time	Frames	What's on screen	Same in all 4?
0:00–0:03	1–90	**Opening** (one of the four in section 4)	No, the only difference
0:03–0:06	91–180	Beat 1: hand pours cold milk into a mug	Yes
0:06–0:12	181–360	Beat 2: frother in, button press, close-up of foam rising (**proof moment**)	Yes
0:12–0:17	361–510	Beat 3: foam poured over coffee, a sip	Yes
0:17–0:20	511–600	Beat 4: product held to camera: "Honestly, my favorite $20 buy."	Yes

Step 2 · Camera setup (5 min, once, then don't touch it)

iPhone menu names shown; Android has the same options under similar names.

- **Settings → Camera → Record Video → 4K at 30 fps.** Not 24, not 60. The checker rejects anything but exactly 30.
- **Turn off "Auto FPS."** It quietly drops the frame rate in dim light.
- **Turn off "HDR Video."** HDR looks washed out after export and shifts color between clips.
- **Lock focus and exposure:** long-press the subject until "AE/AF Lock" appears.
- **Vertical, 1× zoom** (no digital zoom), clean lens.
- **Light:** one window to the side, every shot in one session. Not the body at noon and the openings at dusk.
- **Sound:** a clip-on mic if you have one, otherwise the phone about arm's length away in a quiet room. Record **10 seconds of silence** (room tone) at the end so the editor can fill gaps.

Step 3 · Shot list (about 45 min)

Shot	Takes	Notes
Body beats 1–4	3 each	Start every take mid-action. Speak naturally, don't read.
Plate	1 (6 seconds long)	Steady, nothing moving. It becomes both the cold and the text opening.
Spoken opening	5	Look into the lens. Finish the line by about 2.8 seconds.
Visual opening	5	The motion moment. No talking.
Room tone	1 (10 seconds)	Silence in the same room, nobody moving.

Step 4 · Edit (Lucas or the shooter, about 45 min)

1. **Edit the body once**: beats 1–4, color, sound level, captions (Caption preset). Export it as one file, `base07_body_master.mov`. From here on, **nobody edits the body**. Reusing one exported file is what keeps all four bodies identical.
2. **Cut four openings, each exactly 3.00 seconds (90 frames).** Check the clip length in the editor: 2.97 or 3.03 seconds fails. Add the Hook text preset to the text opening and captions to the spoken opening.
3. **Build four projects:** one opening + `base07_body_master.mov`.
4. **Sound level:** the body is already set. Match each opening to it by ear. **Do not** press "normalize" on the finished files; that re-levels the body differently in each version.
5. **Export all four with one saved preset:** MP4, H.264, 1080 × 1920, 30 fps constant, AAC audio.
6. **Name the files exactly:** `base07_cold.mp4` · `base07_text.mp4` · `base07_spoken.mp4` · `base07_visual.mp4`. Any other name is ignored by the checker.

7. **Drop them** in the shared `stimuli` folder and add one row per file to the shared sheet: base, variant, the hook as written, category, body format, persona, anything unusual.

Step 5 · Check (Ben, 2 min)

```
cd research && make validate-stimuli STIMULI_DIR=/path/to/stimuli
```

PASS means the base is a fair test. **FAIL** says exactly what's wrong, for example “visual's body starts 1 frame early” or “loudness −15.4 LUFS, need −14 ±1.” Fix that one variant and re-drop it. The checker never judges whether a hook is good, only whether the test is fair.

11. Three filled-in Base Cards

	Base A	Base B	Base C
Product	Milk frother	Pet-hair roller	Insulated water bottle
Persona	C	C	B
Problem	“Café foam at home is impossible”	“Dog hair on the couch never comes off”	(routine: a work-from-home desk day)
Proof moment	Foam rising in the mug	One roll leaves a clean stripe through the hair	Ice still in it at 5 pm
Body format	Demo	Problem → solution	Routine integration
spoken	“If you drink coffee every morning, you need this.”	“Dog owners, I found the thing.”	“This is the only thing on my desk I'd rebuy.”
text	“POV: you stopped paying $6 for lattes”	“Stop using tape on your couch”	“5 pm and there's still ice in it”
visual	Foam spilling over the rim	Roller dragged through a hairy cushion, clean stripe	Ice rattling as the bottle is shaken toward the camera
cold	Frother next to a mug, still	Roller on the couch arm, still	Bottle on the desk, still

12. Rules that don't bend

Area	Rule	Why
Specs	1080 × 1920 vertical · exactly 30 fps · every variant 20.00 s · openings exactly 90 frames · sound at −14 LUFS ±1 (the checker measures it)	The checker rejects anything else
Brands	No visible logos or brand names (tape over or turn away) **unless Ben already has the brand's written OK** to run paid ads. Want to feature a brand? Send Ben the contact first.	Our ad account would be advertising their product. A creator's whitelisting or usage-rights deal doesn't cover that; those rights go from creator to brand, not the other way.
Ad review	No health or skin claims, no before/after, no supplements, weight loss, alcohol, cannabis, money claims	A rejected variant kills its whole base
Music	None by default. Royalty-free only, with Lucas's OK, and in the body only (never across the 3-second cut)	Copyrighted music gets ads muted or rejected
People	Nobody on camera who hasn't agreed to appear in ads	Consent
The body	Never re-trim, re-color or re-level the body inside one variant	Different bodies = the base measures nothing

Permission (everyone who films replies with this or equivalent wording)

> “I filmed these clips and I own them. I give Team 2 permission to run them as paid ads for a research study and to publish the results in aggregate. I keep copyright. I can withdraw the clips any time before publication. I want to be credited by name / I prefer not to be named.”

13. Still being decided (don't act on these yet)

- **Brand permission in the pre-registration.** The registered plan currently bans third-party brands outright. Ben will amend it to allow brands with written permission before the study is frozen. Until then, hide logos.
- **Delivery format.** Possibly shooters hand over 5 files per base (body master + 4 raw openings) and a script stitches and levels them, so frame alignment and loudness can't go wrong. Until decided, follow Step 4.
- **A model check on the first base.** Ben may score the first finished base with the brain model before the rest are filmed, to confirm it reads the openings at all.

Base Card (print one per base)

Base number: _____ Shooter: _____ Approved by Lucas: [ ] Date: _____

1 · Product Owned, used, passes the rules	
2 · Persona Circle one: C (paid ad) / B (sponsored post)	
3 · Problem One sentence a friend would say (B: the routine)	
4 · Proof moment The 2-second shot where you SEE it work	
5 · Body format Problem → solution · Demo · Honest review · Unboxing · 3 reasons · Routine	
6a · spoken hooks 5 lines. Callout · Question · Confession. Circle Lucas's pick	
6b · text hooks 5 lines. POV · Stop doing X · Curiosity. Circle Lucas's pick	
6c · visual hook ideas Result-first · Pattern interrupt	
Plate (cold) What sits still in frame	
Body beats Beat 1 / 2 (proof) / 3 / 4, one line each	